

Intertextuality: An Introduction

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Intertextuality

An Introduction

Intertextuality, which has occasionally been used somewhat blithely to designate interdisciplinary and comparative investigations of various sorts, may, in its theorization and historicization, not be blithe at all. That is, we may not agree on its meaning. Most critics agree that the term was coined in the late 1960s by Julia Kristeva, who combined ideas from Bakhtin on the social context of language with Saussure's positing of the systematic features of language.¹ Kristeva's definition, in her essay "Word, Dialogue and Novel," reads: intertextuality is "a mosaic of quotations; any text is the absorption and transformation of another. The notion of *intertextuality* replaces that of intersubjectivity, and poetic language is read as at least *double*" (Kristeva 85, cited in Moi 37).² Kristeva's work on intertextuality in the late sixties coincided with the transition from structuralism to poststructuralism. Graham Allen describes this move as "one in which assertions of objectivity, scientific rigour, methodological stability and other highly rationalistic-sounding terms are replaced by an emphasis on uncertainty, indeterminacy, incommunicability, subjectivity, desire, pleasure and play" (3). This uncertainty undercut authorial intention and allowed Roland Barthes to proclaim the liberation of the reader 'from the traditional power and authority of the figure of the 'author,' who was now 'dead'" (Allen 4). The foregoing constitutes a seriously abbreviated history of the term intertextuality, but the bottom line is its current association with postmodernism, which in turn, is associated with "pastiche, imitation and the mixing of already established styles and practices" (Allen 5). Intertextuality gains definitional specificity by comparison with "other globalizing and rival terms for cultural recycling such as 'interdiscursivity,' 'interdisciplinarity' and 'hypertext'" (Orr 7). Also potentially in the mix is the term intermediality, which leapfrogs altogether the necessity of a text—explicit or implicit—a characteristic that separates it clearly from intertextuality. Graham Allen writes that "[i]ntertextuality seems such a useful term because it foregrounds notions of relationality, interconnectedness and interdependence in modern cultural life" (5). Mary Orr adds: "By highlighting unvoiced modes of intertextual work in other guises—paraphrase, formulaic expression, variant, recontextualization, translation—various tacit critical agendas behind intertextuality's representations become visible. Among intertextuality's most prac-

tical functions is (re-) evaluation by means of comparison, counter-position and contrast" (7). The "tacit critical agendas," to which Orr refers, would include a challenge to the cultural hegemony of originality or uniqueness over reproduction/copy (Allen 6). Finally, intertextuality has been appropriated and adapted by non-literary art forms so that it is not—despite the embedded word "text"—exclusively related to works of literature or other written texts, including virtual texts. And it has a critical function: intertextuality, like influence or imitation, is not neutral and thus hints at its underlying socio-political importance.

The essays grouped together here were originally presented in a seminar at the 2010 ACLA meeting in New Orleans entitled "Intertextualities: Text, Image, and Beyond." The seminar had a dual focus: an exploration of the various manifestations of intertextuality along a continuum ranging from influence to plagiarism and equally a theoretical investigation of the continuum itself. The interests represented in these essays are widely varied and include the interplay of a text and (seemingly unrelated) photos; an ekphrastic commentary on a painting, both of which are treated in a poem; an overview of iconoclastic tendencies in the graphic novel; and a close reading of an innovative graphic novel, which, at first glance, seems highly unsuited thematically to the genre.

Following a discussion of photography's status in the world of art as a whole, Santesso focuses specifically on the interrelationship of text (pseudo-memoir and *Künstlerroman*) and black-and-white photographs (of Istanbul) in Orhan Pamuk's *Istanbul: Memories and the City* (English transl. 2005). Pamuk's work contests the idea of photographs as complements to literary texts, since the images seem, at first glance, to have little connection to the narrative. Pamuk's idiosyncratic interpretations of the photos reveal a subjective metatext hovering between the two narratives, that of the images and that of the text. Santesso cites Barthes's idea of the *punctum* in an image, which is "an accident which pricks me (but also bruises me, poignant to me)" to explain Pamuk's engagement with the photos. The author uses the images to create certain emotions important to his narrative as he anticipates the feelings of the reader—a novel idea!

Gravendyk is also interested in the relation of texts and images, but not together in a single work as in Pamuk's Istanbul text, rather as an instance of ekphrasis twice removed: she begins with J.M.W. Turner's painting *Slave Ship* (1840), which was inaccessible for thirty years and was thus replaced by John Ruskin's ekphrastic commentary published in *Modern Painters I* (1843). Both of these, in an act of "writing back" are imaginatively reworked in the lengthy poem by David Dabydeen, "Turner," written about 150 years later. The proliferating Turners in the poem complicate its reading and comment on the disturbing narrative of J.M.W. Turner's painting, and at the same time, Ruskin's metaphorical "emptying out" of the work and its replacement with his own commentary—a kind of transfer of interpretive ownership.

Quoting Walter Benjamin, Gravendyk reveals a parallel in this text with Barthes's concept of the *punctum*, cited above: "to articulate the past historically does not mean to recognize it 'the way it really was' . . . It means to seize hold of a memory as it flashes up at a moment of danger." This moment of acute awareness reappears as an impetus in a number of the intertextual works investigated in these essays.

Martin's contribution on the evolution of the graphic novel looks not at sequential relationships of influence and interpretation as in the Turner *Stoff*, but at the co-existence and interplay of text and image reminiscent of the Pamuk memoir. This essay, which is the most broadly drawn of the four, traces the evolution of the graphic novel within the comic book genre, focusing in particular on its socio-political function and its innovative stylistic iconoclasm. Within the genre, Art Spiegelman's two volumes of *Maus* (1986, 1991) have played a paradigmatic role: confronting the *punctum* or the poignant moment—the moment of danger—that was the Holocaust, while presenting a multilayered narrative, animal symbolism, and (auto)biographical elements, and also investigating metatextual representations of the artist. A gradual shifting of the emphasis from image to text coincides with a form-breaking disregard for the limitations of the cartoon cells. The resulting works present an interesting combination of ludic entertainment and confrontation with serious topics.

Eubanks's essay can be read in tandem with that of Martin, in that she provides a close reading of a single graphic novel *Logicomix*, that in many ways illustrates and creatively develops ideas initially presented in the earlier essay. *Logicomix* provides, reminiscent of Art Spiegelman in volume two of *Maus*, an ongoing metatextual revelation of the four collaborators' difficulties and artistic negotiations in adapting both Bertrand Russell's autobiography and his search for mathematical truth to the format of the graphic novel. Although the comic format might first appear unsuited for the material, Eubanks demonstrates that the creativity inherent to the new genre, the graphic novel, aptly reflects the similar "creativity" and idiosyncrasy of Russell's life and his mathematical quest. The essays in this cluster address some of the most important aspects of intertextuality, including creativity and idiosyncrasy, and, if we are unable to reach absolute agreement on the definition and specific parameters of the phenomenon, at least we will have, through this discussion, expanded our understanding of its complexity.

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NOTES

- 1 See, for example, Graham Allen, *Intertextuality*, Mary Orr, *Intertextuality: Debates and Contexts*, and Stephen Weiner, *Faster than a Speeding Bullet*.

- 2 For a more detailed discussion of this essay's history, see Orr, chapter 1, especially pp. 20–22.

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